

# To what extent does Nabokov present ‘girl-children’ as ‘immoral and dangerous seductress[es]’ in *Lolita*?

Riveen Kumanayaka

In Nabokov (1955)’s *Lolita*, readers are presented with Humbert Humbert, who grooms and eventually rapes Dolores Haze, his “*Lolita*”. Despite his regret of the “foul lust [he] had inflicted upon [her],” and Dr. John Ray’s denouncement of Humbert as “horrible [and] abject,” in the preface, the social perception of Dolores and the “girl-children” is far from being absolved. Bertens (2001) argues that one of the “cultural stereotypes” imposed on female characters is, the “immoral and dangerous seductress,” which is true for *Lolita* and the “nymphets”, created by both Humbert and society, but not necessarily Dolores and the “girl-children”, created by Nabokov. However, the modern definition of the word *Lolita* is defined as “a sexually precocious young girl” (Collins Dictionary n.d.), despite the clear indication within the text that Dolores was a child who was being raped. Furthermore, Dolores being labelled “vulgar” (Parker 1958), and a “corrupt child” (Davies 1996) shows how the initial reception of *Lolita* reflects the modern dictionary definition. Up to the modern day, both the sexually suggestive and erotic covers in various *Lolita* texts (Zimmer 2014), as well as the fiction genre of lolicon show that this victimised child continues to be seen as a femme fatale (Rabinowitz 2004), who took advantage of a “weak adult” (Davies 1996). However, it will be argued that “*Lolita*” and “nymphets” are only illusions made by Humbert to justify his crimes, and that the “girl-children” are victims, not “seductress[es]”—they are “girl-children, not starlets and ‘sex kittens’,” (Gold 1967).

Throughout the novel, Nabokov characterises Humbert as a dangerously likeable character who abuses his charm to misuse the trust society entrusts him, and engage in his “monstrous indulgence[s].” This extends beyond the novel’s characters, to affect the readers as well, via the narrative voice maintained by Humbert. The explicit honesty in revealing his “localised lust” invites the reader to accept Humbert’s opinion and excuse him, being his “jury”, as not “a cunning adult [but] a weak adult [exploited] by a corrupt child” (Davies 1996). Nabokov employs unreliable narration to mimic the manipulative case Humbert presents to us, which appeals to the reader to accept his morally degenerate ideas in a strangely romanticised way. Through the momentary reveals of his honest self, Humbert simplifies and normalises his “moral leprosy” in the eyes of the reader, effectively creating a case attempting to justify his hebephilia and frame himself as an “anguished [...] man [...] who can love only little girls” (Parker 1958). This form of “bonding unreliability” (Phelan 2007) shows us how Humbert traps the mind of some readers with his “seductive self-justification of skilful rhetoric” (Booth 1983), pushing them to “identify Humbert with the author more than Nabokov intends” (ibid.). Understanding this allows us to see that Humbert’s likeability is a warning—“he is a shining example of moral leprosy”—by Nabokov, not a justification of Humbert’s twisted views on “girl-children”.

For the entirety of *Lolita*, Humbert’s narrative tends to be unclear, cloudy or even victim-blaming whenever there is sexual contact, private fantasy, or revelation of Dolores’ victimhood. For instance, when Humbert rubs his genitals on Dolores (1.13), Nabokov constructs Humbert’s narrative to both focus on Dolores’ unknowing actions during the molestation—“every movement she made, every shuffle and ripple”—as blameworthy instead of himself, as well as camouflage his disgusting orgasm on a 13-year old child: “all of a sudden a mysterious change came over [his] senses [...] his] innermost roots became a glowing tingle”. This continued misrepresentation of Dolores’ involvement in her rape builds on the social concept developed by the reader to view *Lolita* as “a sexually precocious young girl” (Collins Dictionary n.d.), and Humbert as a “weak adult” (Davies 1996) who is taken advantage of. For much disgust, this pattern continues with other unsuspecting girl-children who are merely acting with childhood innocence. In Part 1 Chapter 5, even as a young girl—whom Humbert calls a “perfect little beauty”—tightens her roller skates, Nabokov presents how Humbert “dissolve[s] in the sun”, and worse, experiences an erection that he covers “with [his] book for fig leaf”, demonstrating both Humbert’s depravity and censorship via “fancy prose style” throughout his confession. Humbert continues to present the girl-children in a manner of promiscuous flirtation—“dip[ped] her slim bare arms into [him], “[a] school girl hung over [him]”—assigning an active role to them in these “one-sided diminutive romances” of Humbert seeking “lone gratification” watching children play, stand, or undress.

While highlighting Humbert's iniquity, Nabokov differentiates Humbert's "Lolita" from the real Dolores Haze, even presenting Humbert with multiple opportunities to stop his crimes. Humbert refers to Dolores with "Lo"/ "Lolita", "Dolly", and "Dolores" to present the same victimised child through different lenses, most delusional. He tells the reader that Lolita "seduced" him, despite his initial complaint ("Oh, Lolita, had you loved me thus!", 1.4) and later confesses that "there were times when [he] knew how [Dolores] felt" (2.32). His "calculated carnality" elects to ignore Dolores' "helplessness" despite his awareness of his crimes committed against her. Furthermore, he admits that he "simply did not know a thing about [Dolores'] mind" (2.32) allowing Nabokov to demonstrate to us that the construct of Lolita holds no material resemblance to Dolores. Nabokov extends this effort to cleverly demonstrate the real Dolores Haze, via some of the handful of instances Humbert refers to her by Dolores: "taking things off a clothesline" (1.11), "consuming a wedge of pie, with her eyes fixed on her script" (2.14). These depict a child, one that was raped, nevertheless a child. Humbert's control over the narrative we access allows him to exercise far more than just aesthetic liberty—he destroys and hides Dolores in the meek corners of a line of dialogue or a loose frame of Dolores' real life. Additionally, we see that Dolores struggles with sexual maturity and behaviour at school as Ms Pratt introduces. Nabokov uses the Freudian psychosexual theory—"She is still shuttling [...] between the anal and genital zones of development" (2.11)—to both subvert contemporary child blame for incest via Freud's theory and demonstrate the psychological distress impressed on Dolores by Humbert. Through these, Nabokov intends to warn his readers of the dangerous depraved adults like Humbert who delude themselves and society with false sincerity and victimhood, leaving behind a trail of children blamed for being raped.

Humbert's greatest defence against his hebephilia is the claim of the girl children's complicity in these actions—active involvement even. However, throughout the text, Nabokov presents three methods Humbert employ; none are mutually consensual: voyeurism, money, and threat. "[From Humbert's] balcony [he] would notice [...] what looked like a nymphet in the act of undressing" (1.5). This is a perfect example of Humbert's voyeurism. Even Humbert never produces an excuse for this act, as Nabokov employs this to show that some actions cannot be defended even by the morally degenerate. Money: Beyond Humbert's liberal association with prostitutes—Monique, among others—he extends this to Dolly whom he pays "sixty-five cents plus the permission to participate in the school play" (2.11) to masturbate him at school. This serves to show how derogatory Humbert evolves during his prolonged rape of Dolores, even caricaturing her repressed helpless life into one that of a prostitute. However, Nabokov highlights Dolores' actual stance on her relationship via her casual accusations ("the hotel where you raped me", 2.13) and overt disapproval ("for Christ's sake leave me alone", 2.10). Despite this, Humbert controls and threatens Dolores against revealing his crimes: "I go to jail. But what happens to you, my orphan?" (1.1) and "I am ready to yank you out of Beardsley and lock you up you know where" (2.14). These threats, along with fierce lines of interrogation, social restriction, and general theft of childhood allow Humbert to continue his hebephilia, especially with Dolores. Not her complicity. Nabokov makes Humbert justify himself with reasons that he will disprove. These reasons remain the only accusation against girl-children, yet it falls so easily by the words of the accuser himself.

Despite Nabokov's overt intention to denounce men like Humbert in *Lolita*, he creates a man so convincingly real that readers accept him by the end of the book, where his crimes are more apparent. The reader has to consciously read between Humbert's exceptionally long and complex sentences, garnished with French and false romantics. Humbert weaponises his partial honesty to make the reader believe him, empathise with him, and reduce Dolores to Lolita, and girl-children to nymphets. He actively neglects Dolores' well-being in favour of his sexual gratification, leading to her psychological, social, and academic deterioration. Humbert's coercive and manipulative actions have affected Dolores' life in many horrible ways. Nabokov excellently crafts a character that somehow holds a mind of its own, tricks its readers, and eventually becomes an immoral and dangerous seducer. A reader would either see Humbert coercively seducing Dolores or be seduced by Humbert themselves.

## References

- Bertens, Hans (2001). *Literary Theory: The Basics*. Taylor & Francis.
- Booth, Wayne C (1983). *The Rhetoric of Fiction*. 2nd ed. University of Chicago Press. ISBN: 0226065588.
- Collins Dictionary (n.d.). *Lolita definition and meaning*. Accessed: 2024-07-01. URL: <https://www.collinsdictionary.com/dictionary/english/lolita>.
- Davies, Robertson (1996). “Lolita’s Crime: Sex Made Funny”. In: *Lolita: un royaume au-delà des mers*. Ed. by Christine Raguét-Bouvard. University of Bordeaux Press, pp. 212–214.
- Gold, Herbert (1967). “Vladimir Nabokov, The Art of Fiction No. 40”. In: *The Paris Review*. Issue 41, Summer-Fall.
- Nabokov, Vladimir (1955). *Lolita*. The Olympia Press.
- Parker, Dorothy (1958). “Sex—Without the Asterisks”. In: *Esquire*.
- Phelan, James (2007). “Estranging Unreliability, Bonding Unreliability, and the Ethics of ”Lolita””. In: *Narrative* 15.2, pp. 222–238. ISSN: 10633685, 1538974X. URL: <http://www.jstor.org/stable/30219252> (visited on 08/24/2026).
- Rabinowitz, Peter J. (2004). “Lolita”. In: *A Companion to Rhetoric and Rhetorical Criticism*. John Wiley & Sons, Ltd. Chap. 21, pp. 325–339. ISBN: 9780470999851.
- Zimmer, Dieter E (2014). *Covering Lolita*. Online exhibition on <https://www.dezimmer.net/Covering%20Lolita/LoCov.html>. Accessed: 2024-09-09.